

CS339: Abstractions and Paradigms for Programming

Closures and Let Bindings

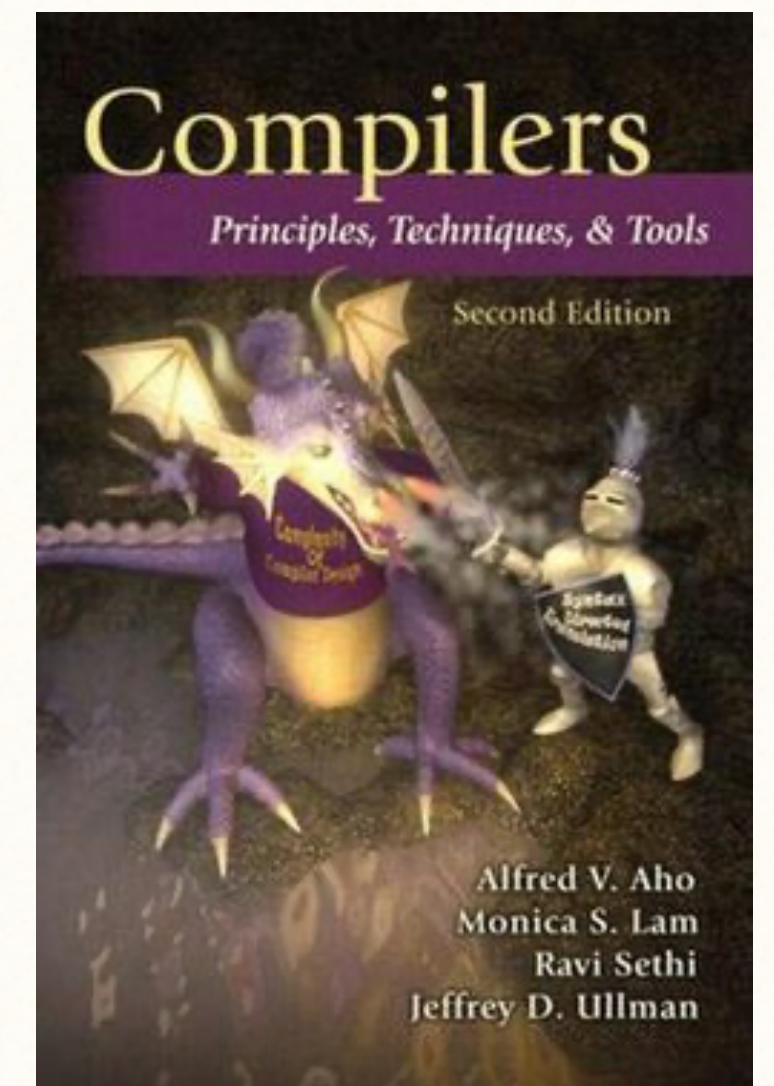
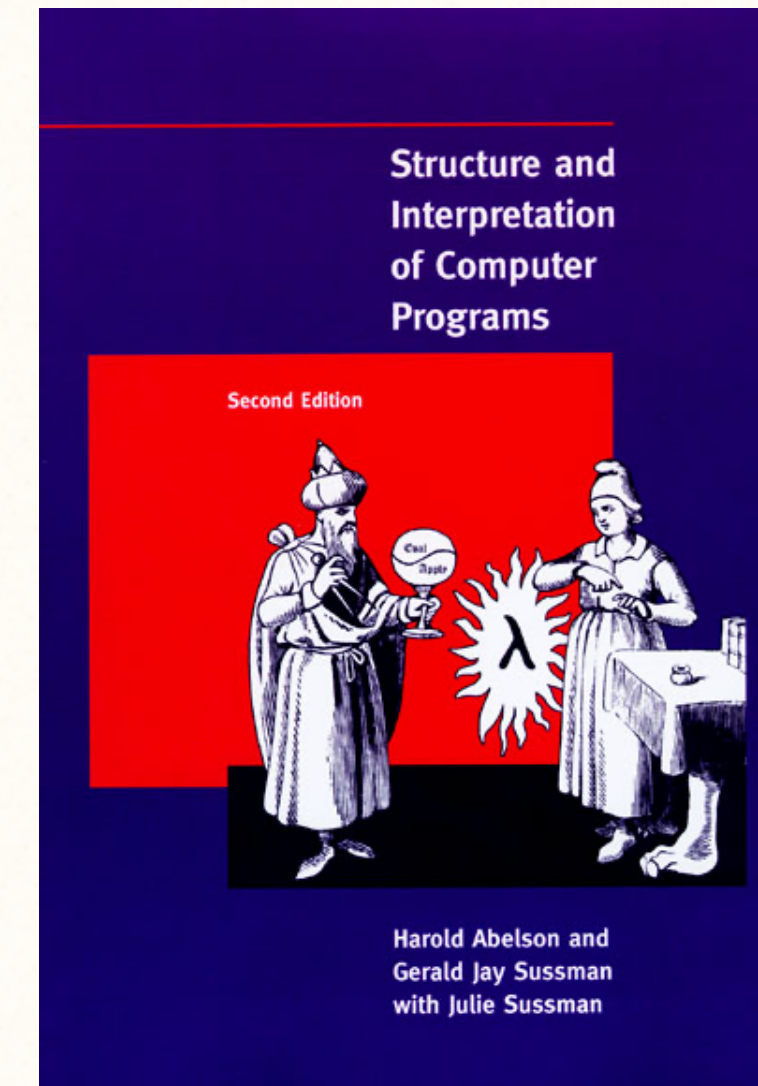
Manas Thakur
CSE, IIT Bombay



Autumn 2026

Discussion

- PCQ from the last class
 - Wizard and Dragon books
 - In fact, PL people are fun almost everywhere!
 - PC Sheet is linked on Moodle
- Follow up on John Backus's TA lecture
 - Not just about hardware
 - Influence on design of future PLs
 - Connection with modern hardware for parallelization



<https://compilertech.org>

Recall: First-class values

- In a PL, a value is **first-class** if it can be:
 - named
 - taken as an argument by a procedure
 - returned back from a procedure
 - stored into data structures
- We had seen examples of passing procedures as arguments.



Let's return functions

```
; Equivalent:  
> (define (make-inc)  
    (define (foo x) (+ x 1))  
    foo)
```

```
> (define (make-inc)  
    (lambda (x) (+ x 1)))
```

A function that returns a function.

```
> ((make-inc) 15)
```

Apply the returned function.

```
> (define inc (make-inc))
```

Name and use the returned function.

```
> (inc 15)
```



Now let's see a MAGIC

```
> (define (make-addx x)
    (lambda (y) (+ x y)))

> (define magic (make-addx 3))

> (magic 4)
7
```

➤ What was the magic?

Where did the '3' come from?

You might for now say “Substitution”. But...

MAGIC continues...

```
> (define x 4)
> (define (foo y)
  (define x 4)
  (define (bar z)
    (+ x y z))
  bar)
> ((foo 5) 40)
49
```

```
> (define x 100)
> ((foo 5) 40)
49
```

Now where is the '4' coming from?

Procedures in Scheme are not simply functions; they are **CLOSURES**.



Closure = Lambda + Environment

- Along with the parameters+body of a lambda, closures encapsulate bindings from the environment in which the lambda was defined.
- When we apply a closure, after substituting arguments for parameters, we evaluate the body *in the **enclosed environment***.
- This also happens when we pass a procedure:

```
> (define (foobar f x) (f x))  
  
> (define (foo y)  
  (define x 4)  
  (define (bar z)  
    (+ x y z))  
  (foobar bar 40))  
  
> (foo 5)  
  
49
```

Note: This is a very interesting procedure.



Abstraction with Procedures as Return Values

- Recall how we took averages while computing square root to converge (via *fixed-point*) and reach the answer.
- *Average damping* is a general technique:

How does this work?

```
(define (avg-damp f)
  (lambda (z) (avg z (f z))))
```

```
(define (fixed-point f start)
  (define tolerance 0.001)
  (define (close-enough? u v)
    (< (abs (- u v)) tolerance))
  (define (iter old new)
    (if (close-enough? old new)
        new
        (iter new (f new))))
  (iter start (f start)))
```

; Square root again:

```
(define (sqrt x)
  (fixed-point (avg-damp (lambda (y) (/ x y)))
    1.0))
```

How is this different from last class's sqrt?

It's not a random *improve* function that we use while computing square-root.



Abstraction with Procedures as Return Values [Cont.]

; Last class

```
(define (sqrt x)
  (fixed-point (lambda (y) (avg y (/ x y)))
    1.0))
```

```
(define (avg-damp f)
  (lambda (z) (avg z (f z))))
```

; Today

```
(define (sqrt x)
  (fixed-point (avg-damp (lambda (y) (/ x y)))
    1.0))
```

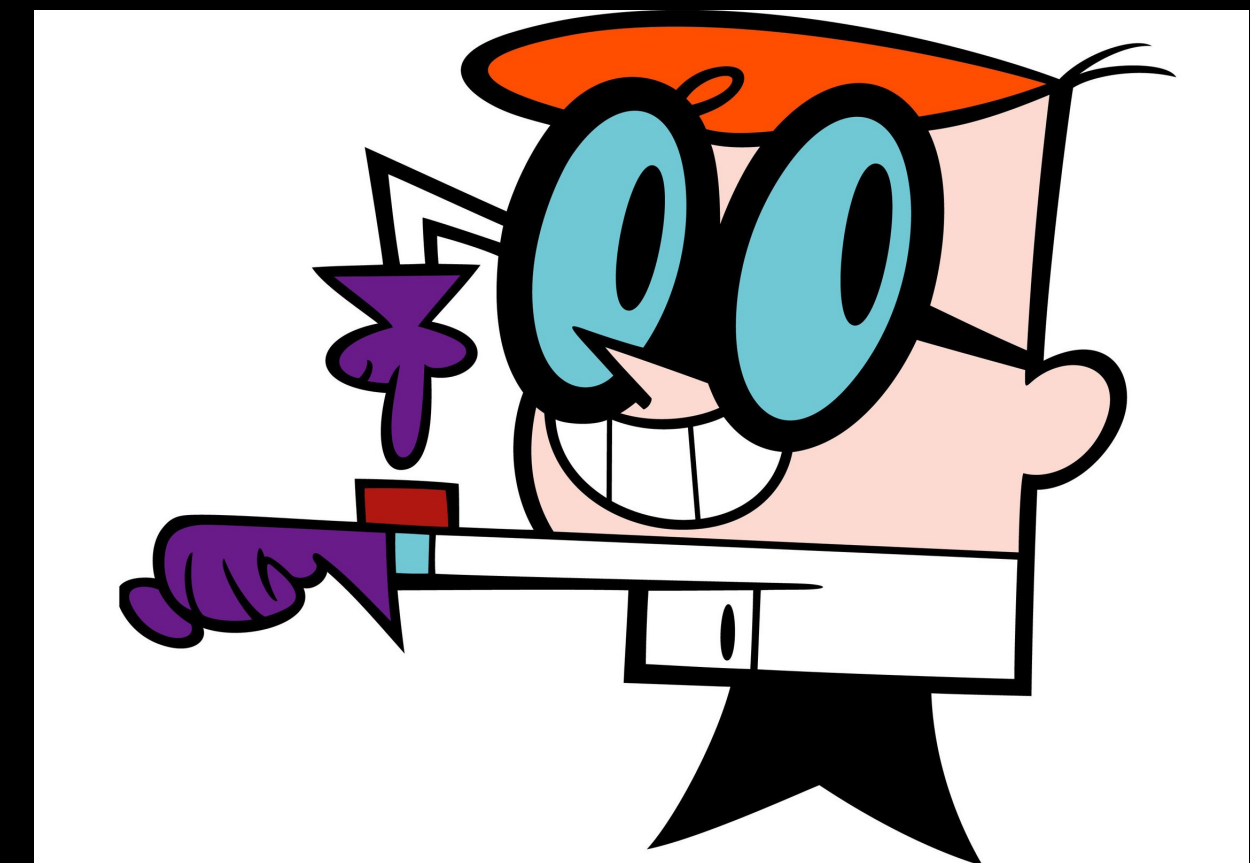
Returning a function allowed us to express average-damping as a *general* concept, and *abstracted* away the specific logic for sqrt.



Lab Modus Operandi



- Each lab has to be done individually.
- Only lab desktops. Fixed seat.
- TAs would clarify your doubts and evaluate you by seeing your code as well as asking questions. Their judgment would be final. We would rotate TAs every week.
- You can skip one lab; more than that would cause loss of marks.
- Maintain a silent atmosphere in the lab.
- DO NOT CHEAT.
- Come as per your batch timing.
 - Batch 1: 14:00, Batch 2: 15:30
 - Mapping uploaded on Moodle



Local Names

$$f(x, y) = x(1+xy)^2 + y(1-y) + (1+xy)(1-y)$$

Let a be $(1+xy)$ and b be $(1-y)$. Thus:

$$f(x, y) = xa^2 + yb + ab$$

```
(define (f x y)
  (let ((a (+ 1 (* x y)))
        (b (- 1 y)))
    (+ (* x (square a))
      (* y b)
      (* a b))))
```

let bindings

let body

let bindings are created simultaneously, and **let** body is evaluated with respect to those bindings.



Let's Practice

```
> (define x 2)
> (let ((x 3)
        (y (+ x 2)))
    (* x y))
```

➤ 15? 12? Error? 6?

➤ 12

➤ When will there be an error?

➤ Remove (define x 2)

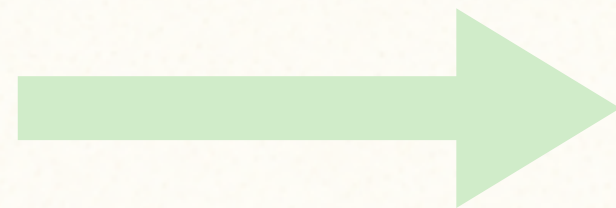
let bindings are created *simultaneously*, and **let** body is evaluated with respect to those bindings.



Which syntax are we sugar for?

let bindings are created *simultaneously*, and **let** body is evaluated with respect to those bindings.

```
> (define (f x y)
  (let ((a (+ 1 (* x y)))
        (b (- 1 y)))
    (+ (* x (square a))
       (* y b)
       (* a b))))
> (f 2 3)
```

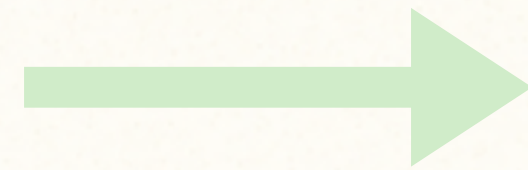


```
> (define (f x y)
  ((lambda (a b)
    (+ (* x (square a))
       (* y b)
       (* a b)))
    (+ 1 (* x y))
    (- 1 y)))
> (f 2 3)
```


Lambda-Lambda Everywhere!

```
> (define (f x y)
  ((lambda (a b)
    (+ (* x (square a))
      (* y b)
      (* a b))))
  (+ 1 (* x y))
  (- 1 y)))

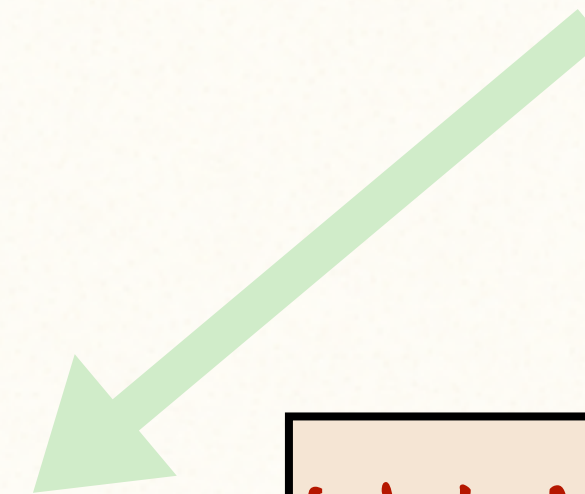
> (f 2 3)
```



```
> (define (f x y)
  ((lambda (a b)
    (+ (* x ((lambda (x) (* x x)) a))
      (* y b)
      (* a b))))
  (+ 1 (* x y))
  (- 1 y)))

> (f 2 3)
```

```
> ((lambda (x y)
  ((lambda (a b)
    (+ (* x ((lambda (x) (* x x)) a))
      (* y b)
      (* a b))))
  (+ 1 (* x y))
  (- 1 y)))
2 3)
```



With **Lambda Calculus**, we can even remove the numbers and operators :-)

Unevaluated...



A "language"
with no numbers, no
strings, no built-ins — and yet
everything you've ever
computed, in any PL, lives
inside it.